

# Lesson 6.3 — The Portfolio Narrative and Closing Q&A

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**The interview is a narrative. You are the protagonist. AI is a supporting character.** This lesson teaches you how to tell the story.

By the end of this lesson:

- You will have a 90-second portfolio narrative that frames AI use as professional craft.
- You will have a complete catalog of 18 prepared answers — the AI-related questions you are 99 percent likely to be asked.
- You will know the three closing questions to ask the interviewer.
- You will have a 30/60/90-day promise that turns “would you hire me?” into “let’s hire you.”

This is the final lesson of the course. It is the one to re-read the morning of every interview.

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### 1. The narrative arc

Every memorable candidate follows the same shape. The hiring committee discusses you in three sentences:

1. *“They’re a strong engineer who [specific technical strength].”*
2. *“They use AI well — [specific behavior that signals craft].”*
3. *“They’d be good for [specific team outcome] in their first year.”*

If those three sentences happen, you get the offer. If they don’t, you don’t. **Your job is to plant those three sentences in the interviewer’s head.**

This lesson constructs each sentence.

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## 2. The 90-second portfolio narrative

The opening when an interviewer says “tell me about yourself” or “walk me through your background.”

### The shape

1. **Identity** (10 sec): one sentence about who you are professionally.
2. **Recent project** (30 sec): the most relevant project, what you built, what was hard.
3. **AI integration** (20 sec): how AI fit in, what you owned, what it owned.
4. **Pivot** (15 sec): one trade-off you’d revisit.
5. **The hook** (15 sec): the one detail that ties it all together and asks for engagement.

### A worked template

Adapt this to your real history.

*“I’m a [N]-year frontend / fullstack / backend / engineer specializing in [STACK]. Most recently I built a fantasy-sports application — a Next.js app with TypeScript and Recharts, an event-driven scoring engine, and a Vercel-hosted live deployment.*

*The interesting parts were two: separating the pure scoring logic into a tested, side-effect-free library so the UI was just a different lens on it, and pivoting team-data into match-data for the analytics charts — that was a fun data-shape problem.*

*I used AI heavily — Cascade for the agentic editing, ChatGPT for surface-level exploration. I owned the architecture decisions and the trade-offs; AI did most of the typing and helped me explore options. My instinct on the data shape would have been more conservative without an LLM to spar with on alternatives.*

*If I were starting over, I’d type the analytics data shape as a discriminated union instead of optional fields — stricter, less room for runtime surprises.*

*I also wrote a 7-chapter beginner course teaching the codebase from scratch. I'm proud of that one because writing a course is the test of whether you actually understand what you built. Would you like me to walk through the architecture, the AI integration, or one of the lessons?"*

That's about 250 words, ~95 seconds. **It hits all five components of the arc.**

### **Why the closing question matters**

The closing — “*Would you like me to walk through...*” — gives the interviewer a choice. They feel like a participant, not an audience. **Always end an opening monologue with a forked invitation.**

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## **3. The 18-question catalog**

These are the questions that come up in 95 percent of AI-context interviews. Have a prepared answer for each. Each one has been covered somewhere in this course; this is the index.

### **Foundation questions (Chapter 1)**

1. *“Tell me how you use AI in your day-to-day work.”* ¶ 1.1 (30-second self-intro line)
2. *“Are you a vibe coder?”* ¶ 1.1 (good vs bad version)
3. *“What’s the difference between AI generations of tools?”* ¶ 1.1 (the five generations)

### **The big question (Chapter 2)**

4. *“Why do we still need human developers?”* ¶ 2.2 (seven pillars, 90-second master answer)
5. *“AI is getting better fast — what about in 5 years?”* ¶ 2.2 (the bar for senior went up too)
6. *“Tell me a time you didn’t trust the AI.”* ¶ 2.3 (case 1 / case 5 STAR story)

### **Prompt mastery (Chapter 3)**

7. *“Show me a recent prompt you wrote.”* ¶ 3.1 (six-component analysis)
8. *“Show me a recent prompt that produced bad output.”* ¶ 3.3 (rejection story)

9. *"Do you use system prompts / custom instructions?"* ¶ 3.1 (project-level system prompt answer)

#### **Live skill (Chapter 4)**

10. *"Build a small feature with AI in front of me."* ¶ 4.1 (live pair-programming playbook)  
11. *"Debug this AI-generated bug."* ¶ 4.2 (four-step diagnosis flowchart)  
12. *"Review this AI-generated PR."* ¶ 4.3 (eleven-item checklist)

#### **Architecture (Chapter 5)**

13. *"How would you design X — and where does AI fit?"* ¶ 5.2 (60-min walkthrough)  
14. *"What architectural decisions can the AI not make for you?"* ¶ 5.1 (six categories)  
15. *"How would you choose between A and B?"* ¶ 5.3 (five-step trade-off structure)

#### **Risks and culture (Chapter 6)**

16. *"What's a risk you take seriously?"* ¶ 6.1 (one of five risks, 30-second answer)  
17. *"AI ships a bug — whose fault?"* ¶ 6.1 (Mine. The accountability answer.)  
18. *"How do you mentor a junior on an AI-using team?"* ¶ 6.2 (the floor/ceiling line)

#### **Eighteen questions. Three of them per chapter. Drill all 18.**

The night before any interview: read this catalog. Tap each one. If you can deliver the answer for any item without notes, move on. If you stumble on three or more, re-read the relevant chapter.

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### **4. The "what would you do differently?" question**

A separate question because it traps so many candidates. The wrong answer is *"nothing."* The right answer is three concrete, modest, technically literate trade-offs.

#### **Template**

*"Three things. First, [a type / boundary / abstraction] I'd revisit — [specific reason rooted in the project]. Second, [a tooling / testing / observability gap] I'd close*

– [specific reason]. Third, [a documentation / mentorship / cultural artifact] I'd add – [specific reason]."

### Worked example

*"Three things. First, the agreement-data shape – I used optional fields when a discriminated union would have been stricter. Looks fine in code review, opens the door to runtime surprises if a future contributor adds a fourth shape variant.*

*Second, observability – I have unit tests but no production telemetry. If this had real users, I'd want metric counts on each scoring path so a silent failure surfaces in dashboards.*

*Third, the AI-prompt log – I didn't keep one for this project. For my next portfolio piece I'd commit a `PROMPTS.md` showing the 30 most influential prompts and what they produced. It's a teaching artifact and also a record of my thinking that I could refer back to."*

That answer:

- Names three things, not one.
- Roots each in a specific consequence.
- Mixes technical (types), operational (telemetry), and meta (prompt log).
- Closes with a self-aware line about *next time*.

**The interviewer thinks: this person reflects on their work. Senior signal.**

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## 5. The three closing questions to ask the interviewer

When the interviewer says *"Do you have any questions for me?"* you are not free. You are still on stage. **The right questions signal one final layer of seniority.**

### 5.1. The codebase question

*"What's the one part of your codebase that everyone agrees needs a rewrite, but nobody has time for?"*

This question reveals: where the technical debt is, how the team handles it, whether the team has the honesty to acknowledge it. The answer tells you a *lot* about whether you

want the job.

## 5.2. The AI-culture question

*“What’s your team’s relationship with AI tools today? What’s working, what isn’t?”*

This question gets the interviewer talking about something they’re probably wrestling with internally. The answer tells you whether the team is in the healthy or the sick category from Lesson 6.2.

## 5.3. The role-success question

*“What does success in this role look like at the 90-day mark? What’s the failure mode that worries you most?”*

This question forces them to be specific about what they want from you. It also tells you whether they have a clear picture or are improvising. **Pay attention to whether the answer is concrete or fuzzy.** Fuzzy answers = an unclear role = don’t take the offer without more discovery.

## Why these three work together

- The first reveals the codebase.
- The second reveals the culture.
- The third reveals the role.

If you ask all three, the panel walks out of the room knowing: this person evaluates jobs the way I evaluate candidates. **High-status move.**

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## 6. The 30/60/90-day promise

When the interview reaches the closing, drop this – unprompted if needed – as a final memorable artifact:

*“If I were lucky enough to get this role, here’s what I’d commit to in the first 90 days. In the first 30 days I’d want to read every part of the codebase that touches my eventual work, do four code reviews observing how the team gives feedback, and ship one tiny PR – a typo fix or test addition – to learn the deploy process.*

*In the next 30 I'd want to take ownership of one feature end-to-end, with a senior pairing on it. By 90 I'd want to be running my own design discussions and to be able to give a 5-minute walkthrough of the system architecture as if I built it. That's the on-ramp I'd target. What does your team typically expect at those marks?"*

That paragraph:

- Demonstrates *aware on-ramp planning*.
- Names specific milestones, not platitudes.
- Closes with a question that confirms alignment.

It is not the kind of answer you give on the first interview phone screen — but in the final-round panel, **it lands hard**. Hiring committees discuss it for days.

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## 7. The “any final thoughts?” closing

Some interviewers end with “any final thoughts?” or “is there anything I didn’t ask that you wanted to discuss?” Have a one-minute closing speech ready.

### Template

*“One thing. I want to be transparent that I spent significant time preparing for this interview, including for the AI-related conversation, because I know it’s where most candidates either oversell or undersell themselves. My honest pitch is: I’m a working engineer who treats AI as a real tool with real failure modes, and I’ve thought hard about the ones that matter. I’d be excited to bring that mindset to your team. Whatever you decide, thanks for the careful questions — they were good ones.”*

That close:

- Acknowledges effort without apologizing for it.
- Restates the core pitch in one sentence.
- Compliments their questions, sincerely.
- Ends warmly.

**Don’t deliver this rote — only when it feels natural.** It’s a finisher, not a default.

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## 8. Body language and pacing during closings

Three small disciplines:

### 8.1. Sit forward when delivering the narrative

Your body says: I am invested in this conversation. The interviewer mirrors and leans in. The temperature in the room rises slightly. **Free signal.**

### 8.2. Hold a 2-second pause after major answers

After the 90-second narrative, the seven-pillar answer, or the 30/60/90 promise — **stop talking**. Let the words land. Most candidates fill the silence with hedges (“...so yeah, that’s roughly it...”). Don’t. Silence is confidence.

### 8.3. Make eye contact when delivering the punchline

The most memorable lines — “*My personal commitment is...*”, “*Al raises the floor; it doesn’t lower the ceiling...*”, “*Mine.*” — should be delivered with eye contact, not while looking at your notes or your screen. The eye contact is the highlight reel.

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## 9. The remote interview specifics

Most loops are remote in 2026. Three extra disciplines:

### 9.1. Camera position

Camera at eye level. Not below. Below makes you look up the interviewer’s nose; above is fine. **Stack books.**

### 9.2. The “I lost connection” recovery

If the connection drops, **never panic**. Reconnect. Open with: “*Sorry — connection. Where were we — I had just finished talking about the trade-off in the leaderboard cache.*” That

sentence demonstrates: you held context across the disruption. **Senior signal even from a network hiccup.**

### 9.3. The screen-share discipline

Before any technical exercise: close every tab and notification. Quit Slack. Close email. The interviewer sees what you screen-share — and what's behind it. **One personal reminder peeking out the corner of the screen is enough to derail a candidate.**

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## 10. The post-interview note

Within 24 hours: send a brief, specific note to each interviewer. Template:

*"Hi [Name] — thank you for the conversation today. I particularly enjoyed [specific moment from the interview], and you got me thinking about [specific topic they raised that you'd want to follow up on]. Whatever the outcome, I appreciate the time and the careful questions. Best — [you]."*

Three things to include:

- A specific moment from the interview (proves you were present).
- A topic you'd follow up on (signals continued engagement).
- A graceful closing that doesn't beg for the offer.

**Send the note before the panel debrief.** It often arrives during the debrief and shifts the conversation in your favor.

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## 11. Common pitfalls in the closing chapter

### 11.1. Apologizing for AI use

Anywhere in the closing — *"I might have over-relied on AI..."* — torches the offer. **Frame AI use as professional craft, always.**

## 11.2. Making the 30/60/90 too aggressive

*"In 30 days I'd want to lead my own team..."* sounds out of touch. The right pace is observation ✕ contribution ✕ ownership ✕ leadership, with each phase taking a clear chunk of time.

## 11.3. Missing the closing questions

Saying *"no, I think you covered everything"* when asked if you have questions tells the panel: this person doesn't evaluate jobs. **Always have three questions.**

## 11.4. Over-rehearsing the narrative

If your 90-second pitch sounds memorized, it loses warmth. **Rehearse for structure, not for words.** Vary the wording on each delivery.

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# 12. The night-before checklist

The night before any AI-context interview:

- ☐ Read the **course README** and the **chapter README** for any chapters covering questions you expect.
- ☐ Read your own answers to the 18 questions (Section 3 of this lesson).
- ☐ Run through the 90-second narrative aloud, twice.
- ☐ Review the seven pillars (2.2) and pick the three you'll lead with.
- ☐ Confirm your portfolio is in order — README is up-to-date, deployed link works.
- ☐ Write down the three closing questions you'll ask.
- ☐ Sleep.

Eight items. ~30 minutes. **It is the highest-ROI half-hour you'll spend on prep.**

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# 13. The morning-of routine

- ☐ Coffee. Not too much.
- ☐ Re-read the 90-second narrative once.

- ☐ Re-read the “*Mine.*” accountability answer (6.1, section 8). It is the most counter-cultural answer in the course; it has to be ready.
- ☐ Read this section out loud: “*AI raised the floor of what’s possible. It hasn’t lowered the ceiling of what’s required from a senior engineer.*” Twice.
- ☐ Camera, mic, screen-share, lighting check.
- ☐ One deep breath.

You are ready.

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## 14. CHECK YOURSELF

- ☐ Can you deliver the 90-second narrative from memory, twice in a row, sounding natural?
  - ☐ Do you have a one-line answer ready for each of the 18 catalog questions?
  - ☐ Can you handle the “*what would you do differently?*” question with three concrete answers?
  - ☐ Do you have three closing questions written down?
  - ☐ Have you done the night-before checklist at least once as a dry run?
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## 15. Where you are now — the close of the course

You have completed the AI-Assisted Development Interview Prep Course.

You hold:

- **A taxonomy** for AI-assisted work that signals seniority on the first sentence (Chapter 1).
- **A defended answer** to “why do we still need human developers?” — five framings, seven pillars, eight stories (Chapter 2).
- **A library** of twelve prompt patterns and the discipline to deploy and reject them (Chapter 3).
- **A playbook** for the three live interview formats in 2026 — pair-programming, debugging, code review (Chapter 4).
- **A model** for system-design conversations that integrate AI without surrendering judgment (Chapter 5).

- **A complete cultural and risk vocabulary** to handle behavioral, ethical, and team-dynamics questions (Chapter 6).

You also have, woven through every lesson, the single thesis that distinguishes you in the room:

**AI raised the floor of what's possible. It has not lowered the ceiling of what's required.**

That is your truth. **It is the truth.** Now you have the answers, the stories, the prompts, and the closings to make any interviewer believe it.

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## 16. Final words

Most engineers walk into AI-context interviews and one of three things happens. They oversell — telling the panel AI does most of their job, accidentally arguing themselves out of the role. They undersell — reluctantly admitting AI use as if it were a confession, signalling they're slower than the candidate next to them. Or they get caught off-guard — fumbling the questions they should have rehearsed, leaving the panel with a vague impression and no concrete reason to fight for them in the debrief.

You are now the fourth kind. The kind who can articulate the modern engineer's role with precision, defend the human contribution with evidence, and demonstrate the craft of AI-assisted work in real time.

Go to interviews. Tell the truth, with structure. Ask good questions. Send the note.

You've got this.

— *End of course.*

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## A note on continuing the work

This course is a snapshot of what mattered as of 2026. The field will move. New questions will arise. Two practices will keep you relevant:

1. **Maintain a personal interview-prep journal** — every six months, refresh it with the questions that came up in your loops and the answers you wish you'd given.

2. **Teach.** Mentor a junior. Write a blog post. Do a tech talk. Teaching forces you to articulate; articulation deepens conviction; conviction is what interviewers can feel.

If you do those two things, you will not need this course again — you will be writing the next version of it for someone else.

Re-open [README.md](#) any time you want a refresher on the chapter map.